

Strengthening bilateral ties
between Indonesia and Australia
through education and exchange

Connecting Neighbours and Changing Perceptions

Indonesia and Australia

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Executive Summary

When most Australians think of Indonesia, they imagine a gorgeous holiday in Bali - but beyond saying *selamat pagi*, knowledge of Indonesian customs and traditions is not at the front of their minds. Despite being close neighbours, Australia and Indonesia remain distant in cultural familiarity and linguistic exchange.

Whilst the Indonesian and Australian governments have many bilateral agreements between themselves, the Australian public displays low levels of familiarity and favourability towards Indonesia. Current initiatives in student exchange programs have showed progress, but the approach put forth by this policy brief is needed to strengthen the bond with our closest neighbour.

Purpose

A strengthened partnership in the ongoing friendship between Indonesia and Australia is necessary for the prosperity and security of both nations. Aspects of our diplomatic relations are prioritised, such as cooperation in trade, climate action and defence, but expanding education and cultural exchange would increase trust and understanding between Indonesia and Australia and set up strong foundations for the future.

Despite our governmental agreements, research has shown that there is a consistent knowledge and favourability gap from Australians about Indonesia, in comparison to the optimism of Indonesians about Australians. Indonesian language studies are at the lowest nationwide in Australia since 2002, with many universities and schools closing their programs.¹

With our commitments to bilateral relations, the importance of human connections may be overlooked- so a new policy focused solely on expanded connection and education will strengthen the cultural bonds and security of both country's futures. Australia is seeking to diversify its international partnerships, and Indonesia is growing as a regional superpower, so fostering mutual understanding through education is critical for our shared interests across the Indo-Pacific.

¹ (Hill, 2020)

Analysis

Background and Current Initiatives

Since the establishment of diplomatic relations in 1949, when Indonesia's independent from the Netherlands was recognised, cooperation in trade and defence has been very important for both countries. Bilateral relations between Australia and Indonesia are at an all-time high, with the renewal of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Plan of Action for 2025-2029², expanded trade measures through Indonesia-Australia Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (IA-CEPA)³ and joint research with the Australia-Indonesia Centre, led by Monash University.⁴

The Colombo Plan,⁵ joined by Indonesia in 1953, brought thousands of Indonesian students to Australia, starting student exchange experiences, but also created Indonesian leaders and scholars that had ties to Australia. For example, the eleventh Indonesian vice president, Boediono, is an alum of both Monash University and the University of Western Australia,⁶ and former Foreign Minister Marty Natalegawa completed his PhD at the Australian National University.⁷ Current initiatives, such as the New Colombo Plan,⁸ and the education provisions of the IA-CEPA have facilitated student mobility, with thousands of Australian students studying in Indonesia. Australia hosts a quarter of all Indonesian international students, with an estimate of 20,000 students each year.⁹

However, funding cuts and policy shifts have seen the decline of Indonesian language and culture as a subject choice, as enrolments for Japanese, French and German and Chinese have risen.¹⁰ The fewer Australian students exposed to the language and customs of Indonesia, the further the knowledge gap grows.

Addressing Misconceptions through Cultural Diplomacy

Despite the popular idea often presented by the Australian government that Indonesia is Australia's 'most important neighbour' and enduring partner, research shows that misconceptions about Indonesian society and culture is more and more commonplace. These attitudes often stem from "negative stereotypes and prejudices found among the Australian public and expressed by our media and politicians."¹¹ These stereotypes can persist because Australians don't have enough

² (Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2025).

³ (Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2021).

⁴ (Australia-Indonesia Centre, 2014).

⁵ (Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2021).

⁶ (Brown & Colin, 2015).

⁷ (Australian National University, 2015).

⁸ (Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2025).

⁹ (Australian Embassy in Indonesia, n.d.).

¹⁰ (Midgley, 2017).

¹¹ (Croft-Cusworth, 2025).

exposure or experience regarding Indonesia. Findings presented at the Australia-Indonesia Attitudes Seminar in 2016 demonstrated consistently low levels of knowledge about Indonesia by Australians.¹² 19% of Australians surveyed stated they felt they had a low understanding of the country, as opposed to the 66% that felt they had a good to moderate understanding of China. Australian's favourability towards Indonesia was also limited, with 43% of responders feeling very or somewhat favourable, compared to the 87% of Indonesians surveyed who felt favourable towards Australia.¹³

Wider public understanding of Indonesia remains limited, and media coverage can exacerbate recurring stereotypes. The media can focus on negative incidents such as natural disasters or drug cases, rather than Indonesia's diversity, economic growth and growing democracy.

The effectiveness of cultural diplomacy is shown through the people-to-people connections that the existing initiatives provide. Australians with greater exposure to Indonesia, through study, tourism or trade develop more positive and nuanced views about the country.¹⁴

Relevant Stakeholders

For any recommendations put forward by this policy to succeed, the relevant stakeholders must be considered. Agreements would be constructed between the main actors, Australia's Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade (DFAT), Indonesia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Kemlu). Education departments, both federal and state, will also play a role in the funding and construction of the curriculum design. Universities and schools will be key implementers and advocates, guiding students to participate in cultural exchange.

Non-governmental actors will also be integral to the success of the program. These could include diaspora organisations, such as the Australia-Indonesia Youth Association (AIYA), and the Indonesia Diaspora Network.

¹² (Australia-Indonesia Centre, 2019).

¹³ (Purdey, 2016).

¹⁴ (Fathana, H. 2025).

Recommendations

To strengthen and prioritise Indonesian and Australian cultural exchange and education, this brief recommends the following:

1. Expanding Scholarship and Exchange Opportunities

A strategic priority for Australia should be reversing the decline in Indonesian language studies among domestic students. The federal and state governments could incentivise primary and secondary schools to maintain Indonesian education. Providing specific teacher training and partnering with Indonesian schools and universities can create immersive courses and facilitate broad learning, and meeting students from abroad can guide deeper human connections.

2. Prioritizing Indonesian Language and Culture Education

Exchange experiences are the most direct form of education, exchange and building deep human connections. While programs such as the New Colombo Plan and its predecessor have been successful, more can be done to enhance the opportunities available to a wider range of students.

Expanding bilateral scholarship opportunities would allow for a diversification of the students available to participate. These could include supporting vocational students, high school students, those in professional training and those from underrepresented groups, rather than purely university students.

Jointly funded schemes could also allow similarly for Indonesian students from more regional and rural areas, or disadvantaged backgrounds to experience Australia.

3. Digital Cultural Diplomacy

The COVID-19 pandemic highlight for all of us how connected we can be online, and the potential to use social media for engagement in education. Digital platforms, such as TikTok, Instagram, Snapchat and YouTube could be utilised to advertise cultural diplomacy initiatives, such as exchange programs - but even more broadly could be used to challenge stereotypes and misconceptions. Online film festivals, art collaborations and live music streaming are both very popular with young people in Australia and Indonesia, and investing in sharing cultural experiences online can help to build mutual curiosity.

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